

BYZANTINE EMPIRE



IN 395, THE GREAT ROMAN EMPIRE split into eastern and western sections. The western half – still called the Roman Empire – was centred on Rome. The eastern half became the Byzantine Empire with its centre at Constantinople. The Greek character – in language, customs, and dress – of Constantinople contrasted with Latin Rome. Despite efforts on the part of emperors to reunite the two halves of the old empire, the Byzantine Empire gradually grew away from Rome. The Roman Empire collapsed in 410, but the Byzantine Empire existed until 1453 when the Ottoman Turks captured it.



Bridge over the Bosphorus Strait, linking Asia and Europe

Byzantium to Constantinople

The ancient Greek port of Byzantium stood on the Golden Horn, a strip of land surrounded by sea on three sides. Constantine the Great (c.274–337) re-designed the city and re-named it Constantinople in 330 AD. Soon it was one of the world's most beautiful cities.

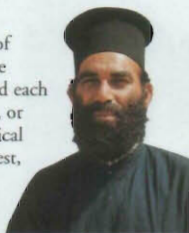
East versus west

By the 9th century, the Byzantine form of Christianity was changing from the western, or Roman, form. Greek had replaced Latin as the official language, and the Roman pope and Byzantine patriarch argued over church ritual. However, they were united in their fear and hatred of the non-Christian Turks and Arabs.

Great Schism

In 1054, representatives of the Roman and Byzantine churches excommunicated each other. This religious split, or schism, destabilized political links between east and west, and caused mutual suspicion and hostility.

Orthodox priest



Hagia Sophia

The biggest church in the eastern empire, Hagia Sophia was built in only five years (532–37). The Ottomans converted it into a mosque in the 16th century, and today it is a museum.

Fall of Constantinople

Constantinople was conquered twice: once by the west and once by the east. In 1204, it was ransacked by Christians on their way to the Holy Land. In 1453, Ottoman Turks overran it, and it became a Muslim stronghold.



Fall of Constantinople, 1453

Timeline

395 Roman Empire divided into west (Roman) and east (Byzantine).

867–1056 Empire reaches its peak.

The Good Shepherd mosaic, 5th century



529–34 Justinian I introduces his Roman Law Code.

976–1025 Basil II, known as "the Bulgar-slayer", gains more land than any emperor since Justinian I.

1054 Great Schism: Byzantine church breaks with the Roman church and forms the Eastern Orthodox church.

1096 First Crusade: European army joins Byzantine army at Constantinople.

1204 Fourth Crusaders sack Constantinople.

1453 Ottoman Turks capture Constantinople, ending the empire.



Extent of Byzantine Empire, c.565

Because of its fabulous wealth, superb shipbuilding facilities, and strategic position between Asia and Europe, the Byzantine Empire was under almost constant siege by its powerful neighbours – Persia, Arabia, Turkey, and some states of the Christian west.

Art and religion

Byzantine churches were famous for their interiors, which were lavishly decorated on a huge scale, with painted icons and intricate mosaic images of Christ, the Virgin, and saints.

Icons

In the 8th century, the empire was racked by arguments over whether it was idolatrous to worship beautiful religious statues and paintings, known as icons. Finally in 843, it was declared to be legitimate, and their production increased. Later, icons were portable, and collected by Renaissance artists.

St Gregory of Nazianzus

Virgin and Child

St John Chrysostom



Triptych icon, 12th century

Gilt covering



Christ Pantokrator, 11th century

Mosaics

Byzantine artists pressed cubes of tinted glass, marble, or precious stones into beeswax or lime plaster to make a mosaic. The artists often decorated the images with gold and silver leaf.

Emperor Justinian I

Justinian I (r.527–565), expanded the empire in the west by conquering North Africa, southern Spain, and Italy, while holding off the Persian threat in the east. In addition Justinian built Hagia Sophia, and his Codex Justinianus, or Roman Law Code, still forms the basis of the legal system in many European countries.



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